

incredibly nice guy in the locker room," said Nick Kyrgios, the 2022 Wimbledon finalist. "You always see him as super professional, but he's like a sponge. Ever since he came on tour [in 2019], that first match he played against Steve Johnson in Rome, the locker room was watching and thinking — 'Who is this skinny guy who has the crowd in the palm of his hand?'"

One such admirer at the Australian Open final used a fun pun on his T-shirt — "I'm a Sinner."

Sinner says he loves the solitude and problem-solving of tennis. **Medvedev, known for his high tennis IQ, laid a trap for the less experienced Italian in his first Grand Slam final.** Instead of his usual counter-punching style, the Russian surprised him by returning first and second serves several feet closer to the baseline than he had in previous matches and attacking as often as possible.

The tactics paid off handsomely. After holding serve for 45 straight games, Sinner was broken in the third and ninth games of the 6-3 opening set. "We've flipped the script," said *ESPN* analyst Patrick McEnroe. "Medvedev is the aggressor."

Sinner should have taken the advice of 1920s tennis champion and genius Bill Tilden: "Always change a losing game." Instead, he continued to play passively and fell behind 5-1 in the second set. When he broke serve for 5-2, the partisan crowd roared. Though encouraging, it wasn't enough as Medvedev took the second set, 6-3.

For the third time, the Russian enjoyed a two-set-to-love lead in a major final. He won the first against Novak Djokovic at the 2021 US Open (denying the Serb a calendar-year Slam) and lost the second to Rafael Nadal at the 2022 Australian Open when he failed to counter Rafa's fifth-set aggression. Medvedev would suffer the same fate this fortnight.

Was Jannik playing possum for two costly, losing sets? Was he crazy like a fox?

Maybe both. Sinner had a plan, as

he explained after the final. "I had this feeling that he might come out a little bit more aggressive," Sinner said of Medvedev's tactics. "He played really, really well for the first two-and-a-half sets. I just tried to stay positive. I tried just to play even level and just stay as long on the court as possible, knowing that he has spent so many hours on the court. The more the match goes on, maybe physically I'm a little bit better today. When you win one very important game, the match can change occasionally, and that was the case today."

Coached by highly regarded Darren Cahill, Sinner was prescient in two respects. En route to the final, Medvedev had competed in many more games (259 to 177) and many more hours (23 hours, 33 minutes to 14 hours and 44 minutes).

Also, this strange role reversal would likely last only so long before both players reverted to their natural styles. Sooner or later, the long, grueling rallies would drain Medvedev of energy, and his running would slow, and his shots lost power.

Then Sinner, five years younger and fresher, would seize the initiative. **Remember Muhammad Ali and George Forman's *Rumble in the Jungle*, when Ali's 'rope-a-dope' tactic sapped Forman's energy, and then Ali knocked him out in the eighth round.**

Sinner's plan worked but not until Medvedev came within six points of the title, with Sinner serving at 4-all, 40-all in the third set. Nerves got to Medvedev, as they often do to players during closing time, and he made two unforced forehand errors. Sinner pumped his fist after the 6-4 set as most of the 15,000 Rod Laver Arena spectators cheered for the popular Italian.

Now Medvedev found himself in a tactical quandary. He lost the third set and the momentum. He knew he had to change a losing game and that the problem-solving Sinner wouldn't change his winning game. But, as Patrick McEnroe said, "I don't know if Medvedev has the energy he had in the first two sets to hit the ball

Future bright: Sinner is also the first Australian Open champion not among the legendary Big Three since 2014 when Stan Wawrinka upset Rafael Nadal. GETTY IMAGES



hard."

With Sinner about to serve at 3-all in the fourth set, Cahill yelled, "He's tired. Keep working him." Jannik needed that encouragement because he fell behind love-30 and then 30-40 break point. He escaped the crises with three aces.

When Sinner broke serve to take the set 6-4, the crowd erupted with loud cheers, while the stoical Italian calmly adjusted his racket strings during the break.

Both players had losing five-set career records — Sinner 5-7 and Medvedev 7-9.

At 2-3, Medvedev serving, Sinner had his tired foe on the ropes. A backhand passing shot winner made it love-30 and a forehand crosscourt winner broke Medvedev's serve and spirit.